Born From Silence and Shipwrecks

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/88900576.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Marlena (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Kyle (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Betaed, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - High School, Angst with a Sad Ending, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Implied/Referenced Self-Harm, Implied/Referenced Suicide Attempts, Implied/Referenced Mind Control

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Part 1 of Sea Foam In My Veins

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by Princess_Cyra

Summary

Everywhere she went, she was a sight to behold. It was never for a good reason, it was because of her ‘deformed ears’ and her shiny, scaly skin.

Adora could never catch a break in her life, her siren form made people look away, turn to each other and gossip. She was a subject of everyone's interests, and none of it was anything she’d asked for. She wished people would just keep her name out of their mouths, it wasn't like she'd wanted to be born like this.

She’d spent her years at school avoiding everyone around her, coming simply to learn, finish her work, and leave. Adora didn't socialize, didn't participate in after school activities or events. If she were just a normal girl, no one would've known she was even there. Her siren origins didn't allow that.

[OR]

Born from the grief of one girl, Adora grew up isolated from everyone in her life, convinced no one will understand her, until a magicat declared Adora as her best friend and never left.

Notes

Beta read by Thia Kerrigan

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: She Is The Sea

Storm clouds crashed into one another and lightning pierced the sand outside her home.

(the tears of the gods above, mourning the loss of a brilliant woman at sea)

The sirens intercepted her, everyone claimed, and it was widely believed.

(sirens were bloodthirsty, hungry for the flesh and soul of humans)

Just like that, another beautiful soul, forever gone.

It was in everyone's minds for perhaps a day.

No one thought about the young woman after that.

Accidents like this were unfortunately common in Bright Moon.

(one woman couldn't forget it, how could she? She'd lost her *sister*.)

Marlena Vespera was always fascinated by the sea and the vast ecosystem it hid from humans. Despite her best attempts, Mara could never keep her older sister away from the sea. It was like it was calling Marlena's name. Somehow, the world heard her calling, and she ended up with Randor Grayskull, just as obsessed with the sea as she was.

When Marlena was arranged to marry Randor by their parents, she hadn't expected love from the arrangement, but as soon as they met for the first time, it was like they'd known each other in this life and the previous.

After just two months of marriage, Marlena fell pregnant. It was a girl, *Lena's golden girl* became the little one's nickname. Marlena and Randor were over the moon about the pregnancy, and Mara was there every step of the way.

Maybe that's why it hurt so bad when the doctors left the room, their eyes falling to Mara sitting in the waiting room chair with a somber expression.

"Ms. Vespera, the baby is a stillborn."

Marlena grieved the loss of the baby for weeks. Randor and Mara were helpless, nothing they did could fill the gaping wound in her heart. She threw herself into her research of sirens and their powers, maybe she could bring her little girl back?

Why didn't I stop her? She's gone, my sister is gone. Maybe if Mara had talked her out of it, maybe if she had done something instead of just letting her lose herself to her research, maybe Marlena and Randor would be here. Now Mara would live with the consequences of her actions.

Mara sat at her porch, fiddling with an old, worn photo of herself and her older sister. It was from many years before, at Marlena's high school graduation. She was young and full of life, she'd watched that optimism drain from her sister's face over the course of years, until she had no life left. How could she ever live with it?

Her eyes drifted to the ocean view in front of her, watching in silence as the waves crashed into the shore with a violent force only nature could achieve. In Mara's opinion, it was the best part of the storm, enjoying the view of the ocean, especially when she had no one and nothing to interrupt her. It was the only thing she could bring herself to enjoy.

She must've spoken too soon. The waves continued to crash into the shore, leaving shells and sea animals behind, but one of those things was not like the others. Without any warning, the ocean pushed something big and heavy onto the sand.

Mara jumped up, her eyes wide as she tried to register from such a distance what exactly the little thing was. It seemed… human, yet the way it shone in the moonlight seemed ethereal. It shook it's clenched fists, mouth opening to release a loud cry into the night.

It's a baby girl.

Running on pure instinct, Mara made her way to the shore, grabbing the little one before the tides could take her back, taking her into her home so that the baby could be shielded from the storm.

Mara's home was small, a simple cabin with one kitchen, and two small bedrooms with a common bathroom. She took the baby into her bedroom, pulling out a towel to dry the little one. The baby simply yawned in response, flicking her weird looking ears and nuzzling into the warmth of the towel.

Ears weren't the only thing odd about this baby, she had blue, green and purple colored freckle-looking patterns on her skin, spilling down onto her arms and her stomach. In the dim lighting of Mara's bedroom, they seemed to reflect the light and glow bright.

Everything about this baby *made no fucking sense.*

Without warning, the baby opened her eyes, smiling up at Mara while blinding the woman with her cool blue eyes. If the baby's patches were stars, her eyes were as bright as the fucking moon. The older woman hissed and looked away, taking a second to adjust before glancing back at the baby.

She was still smiling and giggling, her ears flicking back and forth while clapping her hands together. A soft pang struck Mara in her

heart, a little noise reminding her that the baby's face was so familiar, but she simply couldn't understand where she'd seen it. It took her a few minutes for her brain to finally place where she'd seen that face before.

Her heart dropped.

Oh my god, it's Adora!

In her arms, she was holding Marlena's stillborn. Yet, in her human body were aspects that seemed to fit more with a siren, the scales, the ears. Adora wasn't completely human, but she was there, giggling in Mara's arms.

Oh god I'm not equipped to raise a child.

After a few minutes of thinking, Mara decided to dress up the kid in one of her tube tops that turned into a dress on the little girl, before taking Adora in her arms to the kitchen to grab her phone.

The baby was surprisingly cooperative as Mara began to look up the nearest foster homes that could take her, until she noticed the salt and pepper shaker on the dining table, *immediately* trying to get her grubby little hands on it.

"No no Adora, don't touch that!" Mara reached out to grab her tiny hands, pulling the baby up against her so that she couldn't grab anything. Adora whined, kicking against her arms while glancing up at Mara with pleading eyes. The brunette ignored her, still scrolling through all the available foster homes.

It was a bit of a bust. All the nearest homes were six hour drives from where Mara stayed. By the time she was done with her research, it was nearly one in the morning. Adora was still wide awake, tugging on Mara's hair to ask for attention. Mara hoisted the baby on her hips and took her back inside to get some rest, laying her on the empty side and getting under the blankets while rubbing her aching forehead.

Thunder crashed into the windows of the home, making Adora squeal and cry out loud, immediately crawling to curl up against Mara’s chest. The brunette gasped, glancing down at the little girl shivering against her.

Oh.

She wrapped an arm around the baby to hold her close, rubbing her head soothingly so that she could sleep. The baby trilled quietly, nuzzling closer against Mara’s chest.

With a pang to her chest, Mara realized that Adora was all she had left of her sister and brother in law. When she looked at her face, she saw Marlena's face, her shy smile, and Randor’s blue eyes. The baby started up at Mara with a pleading look, begging with her eyes alone for comfort.

Mara was all she had now, her parents were gone, lost to the infinite sea. How could she send this little girl away?

You'll be okay Adora. I'll protect you.

✿ . ° . ° ✿.

Sixteen years later

Everywhere she went, she was a sight to behold. It was never for a good reason, it was because of her ‘deformed ears’ and her shiny, scaly skin.

Adora could never catch a break in her life, her siren form made people look away, turn to each other and gossip. She was a subject of everyone's interests, and none of it was anything she’d asked for. She wished people would just keep her name out of their mouths, it wasn't like she'd wanted to be born like this.

She’d spent her years at school avoiding everyone around her, coming simply to learn, finish her work, and leave. Adora didn't socialize, didn't participate in after school activities or events. If

she were just a normal girl, no one would've known she was even there. Her siren origins didn't allow that.

She walked into her eleventh grade classroom with that mindset, ready to once again avoid all social activities like her life depended on it. Adora took her place in the back bench, pulling on her ponytail while flipping through her textbook.

Adora was an overachiever, she'll admit that. She liked to learn, soaking up knowledge like a sponge, it was the only thing that made school bearable. As soon as her textbooks were in her hands, all she did was read. She'd spend late nights curled up in her bed, learning everything she could before the school year started.

Maybe her focus was drifting, or she was simply bored from staring at the same text she'd practically memorized, because she decided to listen to the teacher for once when she introduced the new student.

She glanced up to the front of the class. Her teacher, Mrs. Netossa had her hand on a magicat girl with curly brown hair, dressed in a maroon top paired with ripped jeans. That wasn't what caught Adora's attention, it was the girl's eyes. She has one blue eye and one yellow eye, shiny and expressive. They reminded Adora of the pebbles she'd often find in decorated pools and fish tanks.

The girl's eyes suddenly met Adora's. The blonde blushed, immediately turning away to gaze down at her book, embarrassed at being caught staring at the new girl. When she looked back up, she was *horrified* to find the girl still staring at her. She giggled at Adora's flustered state, giving the blonde a gentle smile before looking back at Mrs. Netossa.

Fuck I'm never going to live this down, Adora thought to herself, feeling her cheeks heat up with a deep blush. She was *such* an idiot! Now the new girl was going to think she was a weirdo!

“There's an empty seat next to Adora, why don't you go sit there?” Mrs. Netossa suggested politely, not realizing that she'd subjected Adora to something straight out of her fucking nightmares.

*No no no fuck **fuck**!*

The new girl grabbed her bag and moved gracefully to take a seat beside Adora, giving the blonde that same sweet smile. “Hey, I'm Catra.” She introduced, extending a hand towards the blonde.

You useless lesbian! You can talk to girls if you try!

“H-Hi…” Adora stuttered, already feeling a blush creeping up her neck. “I'm Adora… Shoot you probably already know that.”

God you are a mess.

Catra didn't seem to mind, she chuckled at Adora's flustered responses, watching her with untamed curiosity.

“I love your ears.” Catra whispered, making Adora pause for a moment. She'd never heard that from someone who wasn't her aunt Mara, she couldn't tell if Catra was being serious, or if she was fucking with her. The feline seemed to notice Adora's turmoil, because her ears drooped and she sat up.

“Did that make you uncomfortable? I'm sorry, if someone said that out of the blue to me, I would probably be weirded out too.” She apologized, pulling out her textbook when she noticed that Mrs. Netossa was beginning to teach.

“It's fine! I'm just not used to compliments.” Adora admitted, fiddling with the sleeves of sweater because she didn't know what to do.

“Oh.” Catra whispered, because what else could she say? They fell into a silence as the class continued, the feline's presence oddly comforting to Adora.

She thought that would be the extent of their friendship, superficial conversations during class that never went anywhere. Catra would grow tired of Adora's siren deformities, she'd distance herself because she found company with *normal* people.

She was dead wrong.

“Hey, d’you want to eat lunch with me?” Catra asked after their morning classes, her tail swaying behind her as she waited for Adora's response.

“Oh. Sure, I don't mind.” Adora responded, caught off guard by the sudden proposal. She wasn't complaining though. It would be nice to not be alone for once.

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“I'm just saying, now that *Bridgerton* has announced season 5 to be about Francesca and Michaela, you ought to give it a try!”

“So long as you agree to watch *Companion* with me.”

It had been two weeks since the school year started. Catra was still eating lunch with Adora, tolerating the blonde's love for romance films, while trying to convince her to try out the thriller and horror genres as well. Right now, they were at an impasse, neither willing to branch out, but desperate to get the other to watch their preferred movie or show.

It baffled Adora that Catra was still around. The feline didn't interact with people beyond her. The two of them were joint at the hips, going everywhere and doing everything only together. It was like they'd known each other forever, they just *clicked.*

“I'd love to come over for a movie night so that we can slowly work through episodes of *Bridgerton*, only under the condition that we watch a horror or thriller movie before that.” Catra stated firmly, crossing her arms over her chest and smiling smugly at Adora.

“I’m going to get nightmares…”

“That's why we're going to watch episodes of *Bridgerton* right after, kind of like a palate cleanser!” Catra shifted her chair so that she could give Adora some effective kitty eyes. Honestly, Adora was fucked as soon as Catra gave her those eyes, she hadn't learnt how to resist them yet and she didn't think she ever would.

“*Fine*…” She agreed petulantly, pouting and looking away from Catra. The feline grinned, her tail swaying behind her in a satisfied motion at finally getting what she wanted.

“I don't know why you're complaining, I agreed to watch your trashy romance show with you.” The feline leaned against Adora (at this rate she should just share the chair with her), munching on her salad while offering her tail up to Adora. The blonde had finished eating her sandwich, leaving her hands free to pet Catra. Adora wasn't complaining, Catra was fluffy and she loved petting that fur.

“So when can I come over for our movie nights?” The brunette asked, resting her head on Adora's shoulders, still eating her lunch, she was almost done.

“Saturday maybe? You can stay the night if you want.” Adora responded, blushing lightly at Catra's proximity.

“I'd love that.”

That was that, before Adora could properly register, she had invited her first proper friend (because she had a friend now, Adora couldn't believe it as much as her classmates did) over to her house.

She was grinning like an idiot when she came home, something Mara noticed immediately.

“Who's got you smiling like that Adora?~” She asked with a grin.

“You remember that friend I mentioned? Catra, the magicat?” Adora placed her bag on the chair, entering the kitchen and climbing up to sit on the counter. “She's coming over on Saturday to watch movies with me!”

“That's amazing Adora! I could make popcorn for you guys if you want?” Mara suggested, looking over her shoulder for a moment while she was cutting the vegetables for their dinner.

“I would love that. Caramel sauce though, I don't like butter, you know that.” The blonde jumped down from the counter and wrapped her arms around Mara's shoulders, giving her aunt a happy grin.

“I do, I've raised you for sixteen years.”

Mara was all she had, her parents had died in a shipwreck, Adora was the only survivor of the wreck, but the attack had left her with the deformities that made her a topic of conversation everywhere she went. Adora didn't care about others though, as long as she had Mara in her life, she didn't care.

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Saturday came faster than Adora expected, but she wasn't complaining. Somehow the forty hours Adora spent with Catra at school wasn't enough, when the feline walked through the door, Adora hugged her immediately, burying her face in the feline's neck.

“I'm excited to see you too…” Catra chuckled, wrapping her arms around Adora so that the blonde could pick her up into a bridal carry. The feline's squeaky laughter echoed throughout the entire room, and soon Adora joined in. It was too contagious for her not to.

“Well hello!” The two girls looked in the direction of the kitchen where Mara was standing, two bowls of popcorn in her hands.

“Catra, this is my aunt, Mara. Mara, this is Catra.” Adora lifted up the adorable magicat in her arms, who gave her aunt a quick wave.

“Nice to meet you, here, I made popcorn. One has caramel sauce, the other is standard butter.” Her aunt set down the bowls on the coffee table, Catra's eyes immediately landing on the butter popcorn.

“Thank you so much ma’am.” She leaped out of Adora's arms, her tail tip wagging as she made herself comfortable on the couch, Adora following right behind.

“Did you have dinner Catra? I'm planning on making pasta.” The feline's eyes lit up the mention of pasta.

“I would love to have dinner, if you don't mind making extra of course.” She responded excitedly.

“Mara isn't good at measuring portions, she always makes extra, you're welcome to join us.” Adora wrapped her arms around Catra's shoulders, pulling the brunette so that her head was in her lap.

“Okay… Now, let me play the horror movie of today.” Catra said with a grin, reaching for the TV remote.

“Ugh I'm not emotionally ready for it.” Adora whined, running her hand through Catra's hair, reaching out to scratch her fluffy ears.

“Don't worry, I've picked an easy movie for us to start with, it's called *Lake Mungo*, I promise you'll like it.” The brunette tilted her head so that it would push up against her hands. “Besides, like I said, we'd watch *Bridgerton* right after, so you'll feel better.”

“I guess so…”

The movie started, Catra ended up in Adora's lap, the two of them cuddling into each other while watching the movie. Dinner came

and went, the two of them were still tangled up in each other, neither parties willing to part.

Catra was right, this movie was okay. It only had one major jump scared, and honestly it was more emotional more than anything. The ending twist spooked her more than the actual jump scare.

“Did you like it?” Catra asked her, her wide eyes shining with curiosity.

“Yeah, actually, it was pretty good, I enjoyed it more than I thought it would.” No nightmares for Adora tonight, especially not with her fluffy heated blanket. “Now, it's time for *Bridgerton*!” Catra groaned, burying her face in Adora's shirt.

“Can we at least get the blankets before that? I want to be comfortable.” The brunette complained, rubbing her cheek against Adora's neck.

“Sure, let's do that. You'll need to get up for me to go and get the blankets though…” Catra's response was a growl, she rubbed her face against Adora’s neck.

“Noooo… I’m comfortable.” She complained, tilting her head up to glare at the blonde, but the look was too cute for Adora to take seriously.

“Then no blankets.” Adora shrugged, rubbing the feline’s ear with a smile. Catra grumbled, clearly reluctant to pull away, but desperately in need of those blankets.

“Carry me…” The brunette finally said. “Carry me and take me with you when you go.”

“That I can do.” The blonde pulled her into a bridal carry, going into her room to find her blankets. Catra clung to her the whole way, nails digging into her shoulders like she was worried Adora would disappear or drop her to the ground. She didn’t mind, Adora had her own abandonment issues, at least she knew Catra wasn’t letting go anytime soon.

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It was 1 am in the morning, they were around two episodes into *Bridgerton* season one, and Adora thought Catra was having a good time. She didn't know properly, Catra hadn't said a word since they started.

The feline's eyes were focused on the screen, she'd maintained a poker face since it started, and it was *worrying* Adora. Did she not like it? Did she think it was lame? Adora would never be able to live down the shame if Catra didn't like it but she'd still forced herself to watch it for Adora's sake. She was one of her first *real* friends.

"Adora." The blonde's eyes immediately found Catra's heterochromatic jewels. The feline gave her an amused smile. "I can *hear* you worrying, you think so loudly." Her hand reached out to push the blonde's bangs away, she'd taken off her hair tie since she was home.

"I like it, the show I mean. Don't get me wrong, it's not amazing cinema or whatever, but it's nice." The feline assured, rubbing Adora's hand under the blankets.

"I'm glad…" Adora responded, resting her head on Catra's shoulder, returning to watching the show. The silence only lasted five more minutes.

"Can I ask you a question?" Catra asked, her voice oddly soft. Adora paused the show so that she could give Catra her full attention.

"Yeah sure." She said, giving her an encouraging smile.

"Okay I should just tell you that if you don't want to answer if you don't want to. Okay?"

"Catra just *ask me*." Adora rolled her eyes at the feline's rambling, what did she want to ask that she just had to give Adora a disclaimer?

Catra paused for a moment, as though she was debating asking her burning question. Eventually she just came out with it. "Your siren parts…? How?"

Oh. That's why she was so nervous.

Adora looked away, taking in a breath while her ears flicked back and forth nervously. Her siren features were always a topic that rendered her uneasy. It was stupid, everyone already knew why she was like this, granted, they liked to spread rumors about it, but the truth was out there.

"Yeah you don't have to talk about it. Come on let's finish this episode-"

"No. No it's fine I'll… Well you were bound to ask about it at some point, might as well get it out the way." Adora cut in, exhaling before finally turning to face her friend. "Don't you already know why I'm like this? Everyone does…"

"I do, but I'd rather hear it from you. Some of what others say sounds a little… outlandish." Catra admitted, shrugging while squeezing Adora's hand.

The rumors about her being bit and turning into a siren like she was a *vampire* were, in fact, extremely outlandish. It was one of the many things she'd heard throughout her life.

"My parents were traveling with me by boat to some carnival or convention, because planes are overrated, apparently, and they were attacked. I was the only survivor, but I didn't escape unscathed. The sirens somehow transferred some of their blood to me, no one knows how, and that's how I ended up like this. Mara has no idea how I washed up on shore, but I ended up here, and she took me in."

Catra was *staring* at her, her expression a mix of confusion and worry. "How- You were a **baby**! How the *fuck* did you ***live***?!"

“I ask myself that question everyday.” Adora responded casually. She’d come to terms with the fact that it was a miracle straight from the heavens, and she’d learn to not complain. She loved living, she was grateful for the life she was able to enjoy.

“Can I ask you a question in return?” The blonde asked, running her hand through the feline’s hair.

“It’s only fair. Go for it.” Catra snuggled in her arms, her purr echoing in the room.

“Why are you hanging out with me? I mean… certainly there are other people who aren’t freaks like me…” Adora asked, looking away because she didn’t want to see Catra’s reaction to that question. She didn’t have a choice, though, the feline grabbed her face and turned her so that they could face each other.

“You think *I’m* not a freak? Magicats aren’t unknown, but we are rare, Adora. Everywhere I went, I was always the *school freak*. No one is queuing up to be my friend.” Her hands drifted down to gently hold Adora’s. “You’re the first person to look beyond that, so why don’t we just… be freaks *together*…?”

Adora was speechless. She had no idea how to respond to Catra’s words. All she could do was smile and nod vigorously, bringing the feline into a bone-crushing hug.

They fell asleep on the couch, Mara found them tangled up with each other the next morning. She quietly took a photo so as to not disturb them, before leaving them to rest together.

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When they met again, it was on Monday. It had only been one day, but when Adora walked into the classroom and saw Catra at their usual seat, her heart fluttered uselessly in her chest. The brunette grinned and patted the seat next to her, and Adora immediately sat down without any complaints.

“I’ve already picked this week’s horror movie.” Catra informed smugly, her tail swaying behind her excitedly.

“Oh my god, of course. What is it?” Adora asked, pulling her textbooks with an eyeroll.

“It’s a surprise! I’m not telling you, you must wait till Saturday.” The brunette bumped her shoulder against Adora’s, a sly grin framing her face.

“I’m so worried now. The scarier the movie, the more of Bridgerton we’ll watch, I hope you’re ready for that.” She placed her textbooks on her desk, watching as Catra rolled her eyes.

“I don’t understand how you can like that straight drama so much. Are you into emotionally immature men?” That made her gag, before turning to Catra with a disgusted look.

“*Ew*, no. Come on. I’ll probably be into a woman like that, but men? *No thank you*.” She responded, flipping through her textbook to find the page she’d stopped in on Friday. She didn’t know something was up until she felt Catra watching her.

“You’re a lesbian…” It wasn’t a question, Catra was just making an observation.

“Is- Isn’t that obvious? I’m pretty sure I spent like… half of our Bridgerton watching session simping for Violet.” Okay, it was more than half of the session, its not her fault Violet Bridgerton was gorgeous, but the point definitely came across.

“Straight girls can notice how gorgeous women are!” Catra responded defensively, crossing her arms over her chest and pouting. Adora just shook her head and chuckled.

“What straight girls say is *‘wow you look fantastic babe!’* and I was saying was *‘step on me mommy.’*”

Catra huffed and looked away, clearly embarrassed by not being able to tell.

“Well which side do you swing to?” Adora asked. Catra, somehow, managed to make her pout cuter by turning her notebook over to show off the lesbian flag sticker she’d stuck to it.

“Point taken.” She started to giggle, pulling the brunette in for a hug before smooching her on the cheek. Eventually, the brunette melted into the hug, resting her head on Adora’s shoulder while purring quietly. Mrs. Netossa chose that moment to walk into class, which led to the girls reluctantly pulling away to focus on class.

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“Have you considered signing up for any of the clubs?” Catra asked out of the blue one day during lunch.

“I used to be part of the Newspaper Club back in ninth grade, but I left because…” Adora didn’t finish, she simply gestured to her ears and scales. The bullying became too much, she hadn’t even lasted a month, and after that she’d distanced herself from school activities completely.

“Oh. Right.” The brunette nodded, because what else could she say?

“Are you planning on joining anything?” Adora asked after a minute, watching as Catra flipped through the flyer Mrs. Netossa had given her before lunch.

“The Photography and Film Club. I’ve always wanted to go into filmmaking, I might have fun.” Her answer intrigued Adora.

“Do you have any photos I can see?”

“Oh. They’re- not very good.” Catra scratched her neck, blushing slightly but Adora couldn’t see it properly through her fur.

“That’s fine, I still want to see it…” Adora moved her chair so that she could be closer to her friend. The brunette seemed hesitant,

but after a moment, she opened her phone and navigated to the gallery, pulling open a few photos before showing it Adora.

There were captures of sprawling landscapes, night skys, sunrises and sunsets. Sprinkled amongst those were photos of animals, peacocks and giraffes, lions and tigers.

"My dad used to take us travelling, and I used to love taking photos of everything." Catra smiled fondly at the memory, letting Adora keep scrolling through the photos. She was in awe of Catra's skill, her eye for beauty was insane.

"These are so good, Catra. You'll fit right into the photography club."

Catra looked up at her, hope cutting through her usual cocky facade. "You think so?" She asked.

Adora squeezed her hand under the table, smiling sweetly at her friend. "I know so."

The two of them stopped by the Photography club after school hours, and Adora watched as the secretary began to lay compliment after compliment while scrolling through Catra's photos. Her offer to join the club as the secretary's intern was the first question in the conversation. Adora stood there, beaming with pride the whole time.

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Being a senior came with a perk that Adora had completely forgotten, considering how introverted she was. They were now allowed to go *Culturals*, inter-school events which had a host of different competitions. Adora had never planned to go any of these events, exposure had given her nothing but pain and bullying because of her condition, so when names were being gathered for Culturals, Adora didn't even notice.

Catra, unfortunately, did notice.

"We should go!" She insisted, shoving the poster to her during their lunch break. "Come on Adora, they have a murder mystery event. We get to *solve* a murder!"

"I know what a Murder Mystery event is, and you know I'm not interested in these, feel free to go on your own." Adora reminded her, before turning her attention back to her food.

"I can't sign up without a partner. *Please* Adora, it sounds so fun!" The feline begged, and Adora looked away so that Catra wouldn't hit her with kitty eyes.

"I'm sure there are so many people who don't have a partner." She didn't look up from her lunch as she said this, knowing it was game over if she did.

"I don't want them. I want *you*."

Shit, how am I supposed to say no to that?

"Catra…" Adora whined, turning around to face her friend.

"I know you're worried because people will judge you, but I promise, if they do anything, I'll fight them myself. Call me your Knight in Shining Armor!" Catra grabbed Adora's hands and squeezed them tightly. "I just think you shouldn't let your fear of other people stop you from doing stuff like this. So *please*, can we go for this event?"

Adora was never going to be able to resist Catra the moment this conversation started. By the time lunch was over, they had signed up for the murder mystery event. Their Student Council President informed them about the address, and the time they needed to show up to school to catch the bus for the event venue.

"I promise…" Catra whispered, interlacing her fingers with Adora. "We'll have fun."

Adora smiled and nodded, leaning against her as they walked. She knew they'd have fun, as long as she had Catra, she would have

fun.

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They arrived at 7 am, just like their Student Council President asked them to, holding hands while having their bags slung over one shoulder. Catra wrapped her tail around Adora's leg when she noticed people watching the blonde and whispering to each other, and when they were allowed to board the bus, the brunette dragged them to a seat in the far back.

When the journey started, Catra offered one of her airpods so that they could listen to music together. It was thinly veiled attempt to distract Adora from the staring, but she appreciated it nontheless. It was also how Adora figured out Catra didn't have a preference to any genres of music, or any artists, her playlists varied depending on her mood, and she had a great time flipping through them.

The bus ride was two hours long, which was why they were leaving for a 11 am event at 7. Catra had her face tucked into Adora's shoulder during the whole ride, her purrs echoing deep in her chest and making the blonde's ears flutter back and forth.

Shit why I am feeling like this? We're just cuddling! Adora thought to herself.

By the time they reached the venue (a college near a beach, damn are these students living the dream), the sun was high in the sky and very, very intent on making sure Adora regretted the choice of not wearing a sundress.

"Remind me why we have to dress so formal?" Catra whispered, tugging on her ruffled maroon top while her tail swished behind her, indicating how uncomfortable she was.

"Because we're representing the school." Adora responded, tapping her foot on the ground. Everything in her wanted to toss

her shoes in the trash can, there was no way they weren't going to give her a shoe bite.

"*Fuck* representing the school." The feline growled, reaching into her back and pulling out the camera the Photography Club Secretary let her borrow. When he'd found out Catra was going, he'd immediately handed her his spare camera and begged her to take photos of the group.

"So when is our event?" Adora asked, watching as their classmates walked off to explore the venue.

"3 pm, its the last one." Catra responded, lifting up the camera and taking a quick shot of their classmates.

You're kidding me right?

"Wait- Then why are we here so early?" It made no sense, they could've taken their time and shown up around 2, Adora would've loved to get a few extra hours of sleep.

"I asked the exact same question!" The feline replied. "But Jenny insisted that we all travel together because the school was arranging a bus. She'd fought tooth and nail with the principal to arrange the transport."

Jenny, the student council president, did everything she could to live up to the promises she'd made, and Adora appreciated that! Right now, though, she'd loved to be in bed with her octopus plushie.

"So what do you want to do? We're already here, might as well be productive." Adora nudged her shoulder against Catra's, a playful smile forming her face.

"We should go get food, I'm hungry, *and* I'll need the calories to carry this godforsaken camera." Catra grabbed the blonde's hand, dragging her towards the food stands that were set up. The blonde didn't want to do anything other than follow after her.

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They'd grabbed two sandwiches from the stall, before holding hands and walking around the school, stopping by certain events to watch as their fellow classmates gave it their best shot.

Most of the events were… fine, but Adora could understand why Catra preferred the Murder Mystery one over them. None of it really struck a chord with their interests. Maybe that was why they got bored pretty quickly of watching them, and they found themselves on the park bench in the school's courtyard.

Catra was scrolling through the photos she'd taken, head resting on Adora's shoulders while the blonde sipped her juice quietly, enjoying the sea breeze hitting her face.

"How long do we still have for our event?" The feline asked, her eyes seeming so big and innocent from where she was looking up at Adora. The blonde had to resist squeezing her adorable face, it was a move that sapped so much of her willpower, she had no idea how she managed it.

"Around three hours…" Adora responded after checking her phone.

"*Ugh*! Are you kidding me!?" Catra whined, her head flopping against the back of the bench. "If I had known it would take this long, I wouldn't have signed us up!"

"Well, I wasn't the one who asked for it." The blonde teased, hiding her smile behind her drink, and giggling when Catra smacked her on the shoulder.

"Well, why don't we go and sit next to the sea for a bit? I'm sure we could use the break anyway." Adora suggested, tossing a glance behind them.

"Honestly? Why not. We have nothing to do anyway." The brunette replied.

Adora tossed her drink in the trash and pulled off her shoes. Together, they walked across the sand, shoes in one hand, and it took them a few minutes to find a good spot to sit and relax. Catra pulled out her camera and took a few shots of the sea, her eyes shining excitedly when her photos turned out as she wanted them to.

"They look so pretty." Adora whispered, resting her head on her knees.

"Thanks, I think I might print them out when I get home." Catra responded, turning to face Adora with a similarly dopey smile.

"Honestly, you make everything look so beautiful, I don't know how you do it." She shuffled closer to Catra, tilting the camera so that she could the photos better.

"Everything is *already* so beautiful, I'm not doing anything special." The brunette shrugged, tail swaying as Adora's eyes drifted over her pictures again.

"I think they could use some better lighting, let me see if I can take it with flash." Catra took the camera back, checking to make sure if flash was on before hoisting it up to take the photo. She clicked a few, before frowning at her camera.

"What the fuck- The flash is on? Why didn't it work?!" She exclaimed, checking to make sure the flash setting was turned on. When she realised it was, she turned around to look at the camera lens.

"What are you doing?" Adora asked, tilting her head curiously.

"Checking if I need to remove the cap or something…" Catra mumbled, her gaze zeroed in on the lens. She moved her fingers over the lens and the other buttons, tongue sticking out in her concentration. Before she could notice what was going on, her thumb pressed down on a button, and the brunette squeaked in surprise when she was blinded by a flash of light.

"Gah! Fucking piece of shit!" She squeaked, covering her eyes and rubbing them, growling quietly. Adora couldn't help it, she tossed her head back and began laughing at Catra's irritated expression. Her ears began to flick back and forth, just like they always did when she was in a good mood.

Click. The soft noise was accompanied by a flash of light. Adora opened her eyes to see her friend smiling sneakily, her camera held up and facing the blonde.

"Did- Did you take a photo of me!?" Adora yelped, blushing furiously.

"Yeah." Catra shrugged, still smiling as she looked down to see how the picture turned out.

"*Delete it*!" The blonde whispered, covering her face to hide her embarrassment and so that she wouldn't see Catra's expression upon seeing the photo.

"Why would I?" The brunette questioned gently. Adora peeked between her fingers to find Catra watching her with a gentle look she couldn't quite decipher. "It's the best photo I've taken all day."

Adora released a flustered squeak and only hid behind her hands harder than before, her ears flicking back and forth again.

"Seriously! You look like a princess. I could take photos of you all day and I'd *never* get bored." Catra leaned forward and pulled Adora's hands off her face so that they could face each other properly. "They'd all be my favorite too." She admitted, rubbing her thumb against the blonde's palm.

"You're just saying that…" Adora accused, pouting at her friend.

"I promise you, I'm not." Catra said genuinely, and the blonde's heart nearly leapt out of her chest.

The moment was tense in a way it wasn't before, like they were on the precipice of something new. Catra squeezed her hand, and

Adora leaned forward so that they could be closer. She gulped quietly, unsure of how to proceed, and apparently Catra felt similarly, because she smiled shyly and leaned forward to close the distance.

"*Fucking finally*- There you two are!"

Adora jumped backwards, her heart slamming against her ribcage as she turned around to find Jenny running towards them.

"J-Jenny…" Adora mumbled, smiling awkwardly and standing up, dusting the sand off her pants.

"I've been looking *everywhere* for you. Goodness, Mrs. Netossa was so worried. Why are you both here?" Jenny asked, crossing her arms over her chest.

"Our event isn't for another three hours so we decided to come out here." Catra responded with a shrug, getting up and standing beside Adora while dusting off her pants as well.

"Come on then, we're meeting near the food stalls." Jenny gestured towards said stalls, before walking back in that direction, not in the mood to wait for the two girls.

Catra huffed, running a hand through her hair before turning to Adora. She smiled and extended a hand towards her.

"You coming?" She whispered affectionately. Adora smiled and took her hand, letting her friend lead them back towards their classmates.

They didn't end up winning the event, and they ended up going to several other competitions, returning to the school with quite a lot of victories. Adora still looked back on the memory of that first one with a certain fondness.

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Chapter 2: She Shines Like Pearls

One Year Later

The whole school was bustling with untamed energy, everyone was taking their seats eagerly at the auditorium in preparation for the day's lecture. The members of the student council were running back and forth across the stage, setting it up with chairs and tables for the guests of honor, screams and requests for food and water were being tossed around, and everyone was trying their best to make sure all of it was met in the limited time that they had.

Adora never thought she'd ever get selected for the student council, let alone for the position of student council *president*. When Mrs. Netossa had told her that she was in the running, her brain had packed its bag and promptly left. She was nervous, she'd stayed up all night preparing her speech, and as expected, not many people voted for her. In the end, it didn't matter. All the nominees for the post of Student Council President ended up on the council anyway in different positions, which is how Adora ended up as the Event Manager, a position she was incredibly proud of.

As the Event Manager, Adora was in charge of throwing all major and minor celebrations of the school, whether it was a small guest lecture, or a huge business themed event for the commerce department (which she was a part of). Essentially, if there was a celebration at the school, Adora was at the center, running around like an unpaid intern trying to make sure everyone was in order.

Right now, she was preparing to host a famous marine biologist at the school, Dr. Prime. Adora didn't know much about him when she was informed of the lecture, but in the short time she'd had to draft a welcome speech, she'd learnt a lot. He was in charge of researching sirens and various other related beings swimming in the oceans of the Fright Zone Bay. His papers were fascinating to

read through, and Adora couldn't wait to see what he had to say today.

She also couldn't wait to recieve the goddamn food she'd ordered for their guest. They were on a bit of time crunch here!

"Hey I think he's here." Adora turned around, sighing in relief when she saw Catra carrying a water bottle and the plate of food she'd ordered. Catra hadn't been selected as a nominee, she was given the position of the Photography Club Secretary later on, in charge of taking photos for events, a position the feline thoroughly enjoyed. She'd been recommended for it by the original secretary, who she'd been interning for. Adora had never been prouder.

"Really? How do you know?" Adora grabbed the plate and the bottle of water, moving forward to place it on the table for their guest.

"I saw him speaking to Mrs. Netossa and Mrs. Spinnerella on my way here…" Catra responded, flattening out her shirt and jeans, before reaching out to smooth Adora's hair.

"I'm so nervous…" Adora admitted, rubbing her hands together, allowing Catra to groom her hair to her heart's content.

"Please, you'll do amazing and you know it. You were picked for a reason." The feline responded casually, giving the blonde an encouraging smile, before moving her hand down to squeeze Adora's.

The doors to the backstage area flew open, all the members of the student council members, their eyes going wide as they glanced at the figure standing at the door.

Dr. Prime was a massive man, larger than Adora had expected. He was dressed in a white suit, ironed so cleanly that there wasn't even a single wrinkle in sight. His hair was short and brushed in a way that seemed messy, yet calculated, like it was a practiced way to come off as disarming to others. He walked with a sort of grace

that was unexpected from a man of his size, and as he spoke to Netossa and Spinnerella, he gave them a smile that was so clearly condescending that it made their teachers visibly flinch.

Adora grabbed her friend and moved out of the way, her nervousness growing ten fold when the man's eyes landed on her. They grew wide as he took in her apperance, and she knew why, her siren features were not concealed in any way. She braced herself for a disgusted look, but it never came. Instead, Dr. Prime gave her a small, warm smile as he passed. Adora could feel Catra bristle at her side at the look the man gave her, her claws digging into Adora's arm.

As soon as Prime went onto the stage, Mrs. Netossa gestured for Adora to follow so that she could deliver the welcome speech. For some reason, something in Adora told her not to follow, a sort of dark gut feeling. She pushed it down and gave her teacher a fake smile, gripping her paper to her chest as she walked onto the stage, making her way to the podium.

Her speech went well, as usual. Yet, she could feel their guest's eyes on her the whole time, an unrelenting feeling of being watched. It wasn't like the focus of her peers, they were distracted, she could feel their attention drifting to other topics the whole time she spoke, it wasn't the focus of her teachers, a supportive hand on her shoulder, and it wasn't the focus of Catra, the feeling that she had the feline's unrelenting attention and affection. No, this was the sort of focus of a man who was obsessed, like a predator chasing after it's prey.

She was so glad when her speech was over and she could leave the podium, retreating to the backstage area where Catra was taking pictures.

"You did so well." Catra whispered, cuddling up into her and purring quietly. "I took a photo, d'you want to see?"

Adora smiled, glad to have Catra by her side, she really needed the support, she could still feel his eyes on her. "Not right now,

show me later, you still have photos to take for the school website."

The feline rolled her eyes, before moving next to the curtain so that she could grab some quick photos of their guest speaker. "I think I'll move down to the main auditorium so that I can grab some photos of the audience. D'you want to join me?"

Adora smiled and shook her head. She wanted to go with the feline so badly, unfortunately she needed to stay here in case Dr. Prime needed something. "No, you go ahead." She responded. Catra squinted at her for a second, glancing over at their guest before reluctantly leaving the backstage area to join the audience.

The speech went on for an hour and a half as Dr. Prime detailed his research of sirens, discussing his future experiment and research ideas with enthusiasm. Adora expected to find the audience zoned out, but Catra informed her that the entire audience was hanging onto his every word.

"He has a way of making every word he says sound important." Catra whispered when she returned to the backstage area with her photos. She sounded suspicious, she didn't like the man because of how much he kept glancing over at the blonde. Adora didn't like him either.

When the speech ended, Prime passed around a stack of papers, it was a questionnaire about his speech, a harmless quiz to see how much they understood. Most of the student council members had entered the audience to give the papers, and Dr. Prime himself passed it around in the backstage area.

When he came over to Adora, holding out a paper for her to take, his hand lingered too long against her own, and his eyes went down her body, almost like he was sizing her up. Adora felt so exposed, which was odd because she was wearing a very conservative dress that reached her ankles.

"Thank you kind sir." Catra grabbed a paper and gave him a fanged grin, her way of saying *fuck off*.

Dr. Prime seemed unphased, giving them a small smile. "You're welcome, little sister." He responded, making Catra physically recoil as he walked away.

"Ew, what a creep…" She mumbled as he walked away, eyes moving down to her questionnaire.

Adora hadn't paid attention to a word of his speech, yet she knew the answer to every single question on his paper due to her own research and studies. She'd looked everywhere to understand how sirens worked, so every single question was a cakewalk for her. Catra simply ticked random options, too lazy to actually care about the overall result of the paper.

After fifteen minutes, the Student Council President came around to collect the question papers and take them back to look through. They were going to their homeroom teachers to look through, she'd heard Mrs. Netossa telling her wife, then they'd report back the results to Dr. Prime. It was for some internship programme, which Adora had originally been excited about, but now all she wanted was to get away from this man.

By the time she returned home, all Adora wanted to do was crash into bed, too exhausted to even do her homework. The day's incidents were crashing into her, the way Dr. Prime kept following her with his eyes, how he found any excuse to be close to her. She'd never experienced this in her life, people were disgusted by her appearance, and now she never wanted to experience it again. It wasn't admiration like with Catra, it was *obsession*, and all she could hope was that she'd never have to see Dr. Prime ever again.

Catra echoed her sentiment, sending a text ranting about how creepy Dr. Prime was with Adora today.

Catra: You should've reported him to Mrs. Netossa

Adora: It's fine, I highly doubt I'll have to deal with him again, it's probably just a one-time thing.

Adora: I'm sure it's nothing to worry about Catra.

Oh, how wrong she was.

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"Adora, can I talk to you for a moment?"

Adora had just been about to leave for lunch with Catra when Mrs. Netossa called out to her.

"Of course." The blonde responded, Catra opting to wait outside while Adora spoke to their homeroom teacher.

"I sent the results of those questionnaires to Dr. Prime, he was quite impressed by your score, it was a full 25/25."

Oh. Oh shit.

"He would like to speak to you in person, he's coming after school hours today for a chat. You'll meet him here."

Of course he wants to meet with me, I should've flunked that goddamn questionnaire.

"I expect to hear good things about the meetup?" Mrs. Netossa asked expectantly.

"Of course ma'am." Adora responded, walking out as soon as the conversation was over.

Outside, Catra was waiting right next to the door, and Adora didn't even need to glance at her friend to know that the feline had heard every word of the conversation.

"Oh my god, what do you think he wants to talk to you about?" The feline asked in the cafeteria, her noodles long abandoned in

favour of talking to Adora about her impending doom.

"I have no clue, but I'm not going alone, can you wait outside or something?" Adora pleaded, moving closer so that she can snuggle with the feline.

"I was going to wait outside regardless of whether or not you asked. He was a fucking *creep*, I'm not leaving my best friend alone with him. Maybe if I'm waiting right outside, he won't pull anything." Catra took Adora's hand and squeezed it gently.

"I hope so too." Adora whispered, praying to every god that was listening that Prime wouldn't do anything during their meeting after school.

It followed her like a dark cloud all throughout her day, she was sure Catra could tell how the impending meeting was souring her mood. Adora's leg was bouncing up and down, making her very table shake as she tried to focus on her lessons, trying her best not to think about how she was walking into a meeting with someone who'd been eyeing her up like she was a goddamn *prize* to be won.

She wanted to run, she wanted to act like the meeting was simply a nightmare she could wake up from, but soon she and Catra were walking to the classroom like it was a funeral march.

"Its not too late to back out. We can find Mrs. Netossa and tell her about your experiences with this guy. You absolutely **shouldn't** be alone with him." Catra stated firmly, clearly sensing Adora's hesitation.

"She won't believe it. All we have is a gut feeling, and awkward interactions. No one will believe us." It was just the reality of being a woman. No one took your worries seriously unless something drastic happens, and even then, people find a way to pin it on the women. *What was she wearing? Did she lead him on?* Some people just don't understand the concept of **no**.

Catra's ears drooped, but she didn't protest. Deep down, she knew Adora was right. "I'll be outside…" The feline mumbled, leaning on the wall beside the door, watching as Adora opened the door and walked into her worst nightmare.

All the windows were closed, the curtains drawn, all except for one a few feet away from the blackboard. Prime was standing in front of it, probably watching the view of the street outside.

"Ah, *Adora*." The girl in question flinched, not enjoying the way he said her name. "Take a seat." He gestured to teacher's table, he'd set a chair in front of it so that they could talk face-to-face. Adora set her bag beside the chair, her ears flicking back and forth, a clear sign of how nervous she was. She expected Prime to say something about her, *anything* really, but all he did was stare, the cold, calculated look going over ears all the way to the exposed scales which were visible all over her body. If she'd known she'd have to see him again, she would've worn a long sleeved sweater and a skirt that reached her ankles, not her knees.

"You are different from anyone I've met." Prime said, sauntering over to the table, stopping right beside her chair, grinning down at the blonde. "I've been in this line of research for over ten years Adora, I have seen **everything**. Sirens have learnt how to speak and act like humans, it makes it easier for them to entice people away from ships. I have *never* seen a human showing siren characteristics."

He brought his hand down to Adora's ear, running her hand over it's sensitive skin in awe. The blonde didn't bother to hide her noises of displeasure, hoping that at least that would make him stop. Disturbingly, it seemed to *motivate* the bastard.

"How did this happen?"

"It's nothing interesting. My parents were travelling along with me by boat, and sirens attacked us. The sirens somehow transferred their blood to me, and I ended up on the shore where my aunt

found me.” Adora responded dismissively, hoping to end this conversation as soon as possible.

Prime was silent for a moment, pulling his hand away for a moment, but soon they ended up on Adora’s chin. He tilted her face upwards, his grip iron tight, so Adora couldn’t even wiggle away.

“That isn’t possible.” Prime said firmly.

“What?”

“Siren characterics do not simply transfer like that, their blood doesn’t turn their victims.” He let go of her chin, pulling the chair around to sit right beside Adora. Prime was **uncomfortably** close now.

“Well then **how** do they transfer?” Adora asked, her eyes wide with curiosity.

“I’m not sure, we haven’t researched that area. I was hoping to offer a proposal to you regarding that.” His smile was sly, not friendly in the slightest, but if he was right, then maybe Adora finally had the chance to learn about herself.

“What’s the proposal?”

“I’d like to study you, understand the way you work, I’m sure that’s something you want as well. That way, we can help each other, I can deepen my knowledge, and you can finally know the answers to all the questions you have about yourself.” Prime leaned back in his chair, waiting patiently for Adora to answer.

The rational part of her brain was screaming at Adora to **stay away** from this man, but she’d be lying if she said she wasn’t tempted by his offer. An opportunity to finally know who she was and how she ended up like this was too good to pass up, she’d be an idiot to not accept it.

“Can… Can I think about it before I accept or decline?”

Prime shrugged in resp0nse. “Go ahead.”

As Adora got up and grabbed her bag, Prime pulled a business card out of his pocket and handed it to Adora.

“My number is on there, call me when you’ve made a decision.” He said as he handed the card to her. By the time Adora joined Catra outside, her mind was racing with the possibilities of his proposal.

“Are you going to say yes? D’you think he’s being legit about his proposal?” Of course she heard everything, nothing went past Catra’s ears. The feline clung to her arm, her tail wagging behind her as she waited eagerly to know what Adora wanted to tell him.

“I’m not sure.” Adora responded, running a hand through her hair. “I’ve not decided. I haven’t even thought through it yet.” She needed to do her own research, and speak with Mara before she made a decision. If Prime was right about sirens not being able to infect people the way Mara had told her, then maybe her guardian had gotten something wrong in her research when she first found Adora.

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Adora had no idea how to research this. Back when Mara first bought her a laptop, giving her unrestricted access to the internet, Adora would spend late nights reading up on research about sirens. She never delved into the reproductive aspects of sirens, because she’d trusted that Mara had done her research when she’d given Adora her answer.

She supposed a good place to start would be **How Do Sirens Reproduce**. That led her to articles about how they reproduced like fish, which would make sense if Adora didn’t exist. Even if that was how she was concieved, it made no sense as to why she washed up on shore.

Okay so that was a bust. Adora needed to think of a new tactic. *Maybe* ***How do sirens reproduce with humans****?* It was more out there, but she needed answers. That also yielded nothing, only giving her answers such as **that was not possible**. Well okay, then how the *fuck* did Adora show up?

Then she finally decided to ask the question that Adora should've asked before starting down this rabbithole, which was **Can sirens transfer their blood to humans?**

The answer was, as expected, a resounding no. So Dr. Prime wasn't just talking out of his ass, he'd been telling the truth when he said sirens didn't reproduce like that. Now that's great, but it still left Adora back in square one, which was how the *hell* did she show up then?

Adora rubbed her forehead, groaning quietly. She'd tried so many variations of her question, she'd read so many articles, and now it was around 3 am. It was a Saturday, so she didn't have to be up early, *thank god*, but she was still unsatisfied by the answers she was given.

The business card Dr. Prime had given stared at her menacingly from her bedside table. If she called him and accepted the proposal, she could find the answers she wanted, but she was still extremely distrusting of him.

Maybe I should just sleep on it, Adora thought to herself, sighing and putting her laptop aside.

Sleep, however, did nothing for her. She still looked like shit when she woke up, something Mara *immediately* noticed.

"Honey, are you okay?" She asked when Adora made her way to the dining room, rubbing her eyes as she took a seat before grabbing her coffee mug.

"Mhm. Doing great." Adora responded, flinching when the answer didn't even sound believable to her own ears. Mara frowned at the answer, crossing her arms over her chest.

"Were you doing homework late in the night *again*?" Her guardian asked, glaring severely at the blonde. Adora exhaled quietly, before nodding aggressively.

"Y-Yeah! I just wanted to finish it so that I could relax over the weekend." She lied, and somehow, Mara *believed* her.

Am I getting better at lying?

"I swear, I need to lock away your books or something, sleep is important Adora!" The blonde zoned out as her guardian began to lecture her again, her mind drifting back to her research and lackluster answers.

She was distracted the entire day, even after Catra showed up at her house for their routine movie night. Adora didn't pay attention to the movie, she didn't touch the popcorn, she didn't even bother watching Bridgerton, fiddling with her blanket quietly.

"Okay that's it, this is stupid." Catra suddenly growled, reaching for the remote and pausing the episode, before turning to face Adora. "What's going on? You've been weird all evening."

"I- I'm fine Catra." Adora mumbled, blushing when she realised that Catra had realised something was wrong with her.

"Okay so that's bullshit. Now tell me, what's up?" Catra shifted closer, tossing her tail on Adora's lap so that the blonde could fiddle with it instead. The blonde huffed, moving her fingers to run over the fur on her tail.

"I did some research on what Prime told me yesterday… And turns out he was right." Adora glanced up at Catra's face, watching as the brunette's eyes went wide.

"You're kidding…" She whispered.

"I'm not. He's right, sirens don't reproduce like that. So now I want to know how I ended up like this."

Catra growled and got up, pulling her tail away from Adora's lap as she made her way to the kitchen. "You're mad, Adora."

"What- It's *my* decision!" The blonde exclaimed, following Catra into the kitchen, watching as the brunette filled a glass of water.

"Yeah, and I think you're mad for taking it. You *seriously* think he's going to help?" The brunette had a hand on her hip as she sipped her water, watching the blonde with an annoyed look.

"No, but he's offering an opportunity to learn more about myself, and I think I'm an idiot to refuse it."

Catra rolled her eyes and placed the glass aside. "After *everything* he did, you trust him? He's a fucking creep, he'll do anything to have you Adora. I think you should think this over before making a decision. Did you talk to Mara about it?"

"No. She's not going to allow it. I'm going to call him on Monday." Adora would be stupid to tell her guardian, especially when she was so close to finding her answers.

"You're joking. You *must* be joking." Catra growled. "Adora, I get it. You want to know more about yourself. I want you to get that information, but there are safer ways to do it! This just *isn't* one of them." She grabbed Adora's palm, interlocking their fingers and squeezing. "I want to *protect* you, which is why I think you shouldn't accept this proposal."

"Catra who knows if I will ever get another chance like this! I'm sure it'll be fine. I mean it's just a research project. What's the worst that could happen?"

Yeah maybe that wasn't the best thing to say.

"You really are mad. I'm leaving." Catra left the kitchen, running over to the living room to grab her things.

"What? But we didn't finish the episode!" Adora followed her right back, hugging herself tightly. *Wait- Don't go, please!*

“I’m not interested in staying here with you. You’re fucking insane to think you can trust him, Adora. Are you going to tell Mara?”

“N-No…”

“Then I’m not fucking staying.”

No, no please…

Catra walked out the door, and Adora felt tears running down her face. She needed Catra more than anything, the brunette was her only friend, and watching her leave was the hardest thing she’d ever done.

She still didn’t change her mind.

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“Adora, I need to talk to you.”

She’d just returned from school, her bag was still slung over her shoulder, and she hadn’t even taken off her shoes yet. Mara was at the dining table cutting vegetables, she had a very severe look on her face that told Adora that she was going to really get it today.

“Okay… What’s up?” Adora dropped her bag on a chair before going into the kitchen to grab a chocolate bar.

“So, I got a call from Catra a while back…”

Adora’s eyes went wide. *Shit, of course she’d call. Why did I not think of that?* Mara had been worried when she’d woken up to find Adora curled up on the couch, blankets wrapped around herself, Catra no where to be found. Adora had told her that the brunette had some work and left in the night, and Mara had accepted the reason.

“Oh, thats nice. What did she say?” Adora asked, looking over shoulder and smiling.

"She told me that some… Dr. Prime has given you the opportunity to be a part of a research project on sirens. He wants to understand how you ended up like this…"

The fucking snitch.

"Oh, well yes. He came on Friday, and I plan on calling him today." Adora replied, grabbing a chocolate bar from the box. It's fine, she could work with this, it wasn't a problem.

"You already know why you're like this, why do you need to sign up for this research project?" Mara asked, and Adora didn't need to look at her guardian to know that she wasn't pleased about the prospect, just like Adora had expected.

"Because now, I can get confirmation that we didn't have before." Adora replied, grabbing the chocolate bar and a jug of juice and moving over to sit in front of Mara on the dining table.

"You don't need that…"

"I *do*, I want to understand more about myself, and… I did my own research about siren reproduction, and it turns out they just don't give their blood to humans the way you told me they do. So I want to know more."

Something in Mara shifted when Adora said that, her eyes went wide and she began to blush a bright shade of red.

"Are- are you saying you don't trust me!?" Mara exclaimed, making Adora flinch. The blonde was taken aback by the harsh reaction, since the situation simply didn't merit it.

"What? No! Of course not… Why would you even think that? You probably made a mistake, and that's normal." Adora grabbed a glass and poured some juice into it, her leg bouncing up and down under the table.

"Well clearly you don't, you've been doing research and agreeing to stuff *behind my back*. Were you *ever* going to tell me anything

about this, or did I have to find out from Catra?" Her guardian demanded, slamming the knife on the table. Adora's ears flattened, and she raked her nails down the table nervously.

"Of course I was!" *I'm lying, I wasn't going to until I had substantial evidence on how I ended up like this.* "I just didn't want to tell you until I accepted the proposal."

"Don't lie to me Adora Vespera. Catra told me you weren't planning on telling me at all."

Fuck you Catra.

"What did I ever do to make you think I'm not trustworthy on matters like this!?" Mara's voice was growing louder, Adora had never seen her guardian so angry. "I did everything to make sure I gave you a good life."

"I always trust you! That's not why I didn't want to tell you, why do you think that's the reason I don't? Did- Did you *do* something to merit the concern?" Adora trusted Mara more than anyone on this planet, why wouldn't she? Something wasn't right about how upset her guardian was.

Mara somehow managed to blush more at the question, and for a second, Adora couldn't process the reaction. Her heart slammed against her ribcage.

"What- Mara… I'm right. What did you do!?" Adora stood up as well, her food and juice forgotten.

"Nothing, I didn't do anything. It doesn't matter anyway, you aren't going for this research project." Mara replied dismissively, grabbing the vegetables and knife and entering the kitchen to begin cooking dinner.

"You can't fucking make that decision *for me*! I can't believe you and Catra would do this behind **my** back." Adora followed her into the kitchen, anger lighting up a fire in her chest. Not only was her guardian hiding stuff from her, she was conspiring with her best

friend to keep her away from the opportunity to learn more about herself.

"Catra was right to call me about this. She thinks this man is a creep, and she wants to protect you."

"Catra doesn't need to fucking protect me! I can take care of myself." Adora yelled, stomping her foot on the ground.

"I don't care. You aren't going, and that's final." Mara replied, not even turning to look at Adora.

"You don't get to decide that. You're not my mom!"

That finally got Mara to turn around and face her. "Adora, I am your *guardian*-"

"Exactly, you're my *guardian*! You aren't Marlena, so ***stop trying to be her***!"

The room fell silent, Adora was gasping for air as Mara gripped the countertop. Her guardian breathed in and out, trying her best to not explode at Adora.

"Go to your room, and *stay there*." She whispered in a dangerously low tone. "Don't you dare show your face to me to for the rest of the night."

"Gladly…" Adora replied, grabbing her bag and her food and going upstairs.

The blonde tossed her bag at the wall in a way to get her frustration out, before grabbing her phone to message Catra.

Adora: I can't fucking believe you told Mara!

Catra: Well clearly you weren't going to.

Adora: It's not your secret to tell. Fuck you, honestly.

Catra: You'll thank me one day. I did you a favour.

Adora’s finger hovered over the block button, her anger demanding her to punish Catra for this, but in the end, she couldn’t bring herself to do it. She growled and placed her phone back on the bedside table, shoving her face into a pillow to scream.

She didn’t touch her food for hours, Adora grabbed her octopus stuffed animal and cried, her tears staining the octopus’s fur. By the time she left her depressed huddle, it was 9 pm, and Mara had fallen asleep on the couch, a bottle of wine beside her on the coffee table. Adora quietly made her way to the kitchen, grabbing her plate of pasta that Mara had left for her, before coming back upstairs to curl up under the sheets.

She finished her food, before grabbing her phone and the business card she’d hid in the bedside cabinet’s drawer. Adora typed the number before calling, fingers tapping her thigh nervously.

“*Hector Prime speaking.*”

“It’s Adora.”

“*Ah, I was hoping to hear from you. Have you made a decision*?”

“I accept the proposal, when can we start?”

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Chapter 3: She Has No Tears

Chapter Notes

CW: Referenced self harm and attempted suicide.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Remind me again why we have to do this?"

Adora looked over her shoulder, where Catra was adjusting her suit jacket in the mirror. She rolled her eyes and giggled, moving over to grab her shoulders and turn her around.

"Because we're part of the student council." She responded simply, tightening the brunette's tie, before moving her hands over Catra's jacket to smooth out the wrinkles. "And we need to send off our seniors."

"This wasn't part of the job description…" Catra mumbled, but she didn't stop Adora from fussing over her suit. "I swear my contract said that I had to just take pictures of events, not dance like I'm part of a circus."

"It'll be fun!" Adora insisted, pulling back when she was satisfied with how Catra's suit looked. "Our practice sessions were nice, ***and*** *we get to the couple dance routine with each other instead of boys, which is the best part. I'd rather do it with my best friend."*

"…yes that's the reason why I like that part of the dance routine. No other reason." Catra agreed, nodding along to Adora's words. "I just hope they don't make us do this group dance thing again."

"They probably will."

"Yeah they will."

Their seniors were still gathering in the auditorium, Adora still had maybe ten minutes before she had to go on stage and begin the event. Catra took her hand and rested her head on her shoulder, rubbing her thumb over her palm.

"Your dress is nice…" Catra whispered, eyes drifting over Adora's outfit. It was a simple baby blue dress with an attached shawl covering her shoulders, and more importantly her shiny scales, all the way till her elbows. She'd gone shopping with Mara earlier in the week to buy it, since she didn't have any proper formal dresses.

"Thanks, it's very comfortable and the fabric is stretchy, perfect for dancing." Adora replied, smiling and pulling away to spin around and show off the dress.

"I am definitely taking so many photos of you in this dress once the main event is over." The brunette teased, giving Adora a smirk which made her heart flutter uselessly.

"S-Stop…" Adora mumbled, tucking some hair behind her ear.

"Awww, but you're so pretty! I want you to know." Catra teased, grabbing Adora's hand and pulling her closer so that the blonde was standing in between her legs.

"You're such a flirt." The blonde accused, pouting at her friend.

"Only for you~" Was the brunette's response, which made her roll her eyes.

*"**Ahem.**"*

Adora turned around so fast her hair slapped Catra's face, much to the brunette's displeasure. It was Emily, the Student Council's new female leader now that Jenny was graduating. She was a fox hybrid who was way too smug for her own good, and usually Adora could handle it, now was not such a moment.

"If you both are done, we'd like to start the event." She said pointedly, smirking and glancing between the two girls.

Adora definitely preferred Jenny as the Student Council's female leader.

"Right. I'll be there." Adora grabbed the papers that had her speech, just as Catra grabbed her hand and gave her a quick kiss.

"You'll do amazing out there." Catra whispered, smiling encouragingly at her. Adora smiled back and pressed her forehead against Catra's forehead.

"Thank you." She replied, before pulling away and running to the podium.

Adora could see Catra in the audience the whole time, clicking photos of the stage and being an encouraging presence. She didn't trip over the words in her speech, nor did she fumble her steps in their dance routine, not with Catra just a few steps away from her.

Fuck, what would I do without you? *Adora thought to herself as she adjusted the rose in her hair. It was part of the routine for Catra to give her a rose which she'd then put in her hair, and she was yet to take it off. Catra was curled up next to her as they ate the sandwiches that Mara made in peace.*

I'm so lucky to have you.

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Adora was dying. Not literally, she was in perfect health. No, she was dying emotionally.

Catra wasn't talking to her anymore, which was expected after the the disastrous way their friendship ended. She'd taken to sitting with members of the photography club during classes and lunch, and tended to ignore Adora whenever they did have to sit or work together.

They were partners in pretty much everything Student Council related, and it was starting to become extremely painful now that Catra refused to look Adora in the eye and say anything beyond *"pass me the tape".*

Student Council members were starting to pick up on the tension. Adora and Catra were always hanging off of each other's arms, the brunette was always sitting in Adora's lap or vice versa, and the members were used to rolling their eyes at their antics.

Now, Adora and Catra were sitting next to each other, yes, but the emotional distance was so thick it could be cut with a knife, and now there was a reluctance to work with each other that simply wasn't there before. Adora couldn't count the number of times she'd been stopped by her fellow members just to ask if everything was okay.

Emily, to her credit, immediately decided after the first week that Adora and Catra couldn't be trusted to work together anymore, not with how volatile their relationship was. Catra was paired up with the Secretary of the Drama Club, a shy boy named Kyle, while Adora was paired up with Ruby, the Secretary of the Music Department.

Ruby was… fine. She was a decent person who didn't pry into Adora's personal life. She was extremely professional working together, and only asked questions regarding the work they were getting done. Beyond that, they never spoke, and worked quietly yet efficiently.

Ruby was fine, but she wasn't Catra.

It was yet another sunny day when Emily pulled Adora aside during lunch break.

"What the hell is going on between you and Catra?" She demanded, arms crossed over her chest as she glared at the blonde.

"Nothing that concerns you." Adora replied coolly as she placed her books inside her locker and pulled out her lunch.

"It does concern me when you both are glaring at each other across the room during meetings. Can't you sit down and resolve it? I preferred it when you two were ridiculously affectionate. Come to some custody arrangement, even if you can't stop the divorce." Emily hissed, grabbing the blonde's shoulders and shaking her back and forth.

"Oh my *god*, go to hell. I have to go to lunch." Adora grumbled, pushing Emily away and slamming the locker room door to make her way to the cafeteria.

The two of them making up was no where in the cards anytime soon, not when Adora was currently working with Hector Prime on his research project.

It started off with a round of interviews, asking Adora about her childhood and her life in general, before it moved on to tests. IQ and EQ tests were the first ones, hours in a room with another scientist, letting them drill questions until her head began spinning. It didn't matter, because she scored an above average in both. Dr. Prime was extremely impressed by her performance, and he wasn't quiet about it.

She didn't mind the tests at first, not when they were simple and almost like her school exams. They were good, even *fun*. She especially enjoyed the agility tests, Adora was a very athletic person so she passed them with flying colors.

Everything started to go downhill from the day they told Adora she had to undergo a medical examination.

"We'll need you to change into this." The doctor - Adora hadn't heard her name - handed her a hospital gown. She'd felt uncomfortable the moment she was informed of the day's agenda by Dr. Prime, but she hadn't said anything.

It's just a medical examination, how bad can it be?

It started off okay, the doctor first pulled out a syringe and drew a blood sample for further testing, before beginning to examine Adora's body. That's what it felt like they were doing, examining to see if her *body* was in a good condition. They groped every part of her, maybe it was accidental, maybe it wasn't, but Adora could feel the tears in her eyes, the urge to push the doctor and Prime away from her so that they wouldn't talk about her like she wasn't in the room.

The doctor pointed a flashlight at Adora's eyes, gasping quietly when the blonde didn't flinch at the light.

"Tapetum Lucidum…" She mumbled. "Fascinating!"

"W-What is that?" Adora remembered hearing that somewhere before, but she couldn't recall where.

"It's a reflective tissue located behind the retina in nocturnal animals and aquatic vertebrates. Essentially it allows them to see in the dark." The doctor explained, before grabbing the blonde's hospital gown and pushing it off her shoulders, exposing the blonde's chest in the process (they'd made take her bra off too).

"W-What are you doing!? Stop that!" She exclaimed, but it felt like her pleas fell on deaf ears as the doctor continued to examine Adora's scales, rubbing her hand on them like she was nothing more than an animal.

Adora didn't make eye contact with anyone, feeling too embarrassed to look at anyone, yet she could feel Dr. Prime's eyes on her, going over her body, her scales and her exposed chest.

She cried into her pillow the entire night when she returned home, especially when she remembered how Mara had ignored her when she'd asked her guardian how her day was.

Her performance at school was dipping, it became common for her to fall asleep during classes, and her contributions to the Student Council grew sparse. She'd started missing school,

sleeping in till 1, even 2 PM. It wasn't immediate, but soon, everyone in school began to notice the change.

"Ms. Vespera." Mrs. Netossa called out as the students began to file out of the room. Adora paused as she packed her books, knowing everyone's eyes were on her. She looked up at her teacher, her hands shaking as she held her books.

"Stay back for a few minutes." She requested, before returning to her desk. The students began to leave the room, but Adora noticed Catra hanging back, waiting just outside the room. Mrs. Netossa seemed to notice too.

"Ms. Lily Rose, I seem to recall only asking Ms. Vespera to stay back." Mrs. Netossa pointed out, giving the brunette a very severe look. Catra ducked her dead and ran down the hall, much to Adora's displeasure. Despite everything, Adora couldn't handle all this without her best friend just outside, ready to comfort her.

Mrs. Netossa gestured to the chair in front of her desk, and Adora quietly sat down, her leg bouncing up and down. Her teacher was silent for a moment, watching the blonde with an unreadable expression. She'd expected a lot of things, reprimands for missed days of school, sleeping during class hours, not assisting the student council. What she hadn't expected was, "Are you okay, Adora?"

"H-Huh…" Adora whispered, glancing up at her teacher with wide, confused eyes.

"I asked if you were okay. You've been missing class, and if you *are* there, you're sleeping. You were always so involved in the council, and now it just… feels like you're a shadow of what you were." Mrs. Netossa sat down on the chair behind the table, crossing one leg on top of the other. "I've heard the rumors from the student council, that you've not spoken to Catra. You both were *inseparable*, what happened Adora?"

Adora gulped, fiddling with her hands under the table. “N-Nothing happened, we just grew apart.”

“I find that hard to believe. You two were joined at the hip.” Her teacher replied, squinting at the blonde. Adora shrunk in her chair, looking away and glancing the floor.

“Did you tell her how you felt? Did she not feel the same way?” The older woman asked, making Adora turn back to face her sharply.

“H-How I *felt*?” Adora asked incredulously, tapping her thigh with her fingers.

“Yes, how you feel. Everyone can tell that you like her, Adora. It’s not subtle.” Mrs. Netossa said kindly, her voice was calm and it grounded Adora, which was good because the blonde really needed it at that moment.

*Everyone can tell that you **like her**…* The words echoed in her head, her head began to spin out of control as Adora tried to wrap her mind around them. She understood what they meant individually, but as a sentence Adora couldn’t process them.

Was it normal to understand that you loved your best friend because someone pointed it out? Was it usual to find out your feelings when your friendship was effectively over?

Adora rested her head back against the chair, tears streaming down her face. She hurriedly brought her hand up to her face to wipe them off, but it was too late. Mrs. Netossa had already noticed.

“Oh Adora, I’m so sorry.” She whispered. It didn’t feel condescending, it was the first genuine words she’d heard in a long time. “I get it, your first heartbreak can feel like the end of the world. I’ve also experienced it, and goodness it *sucked.* I promise, it’ll get better, and if you need someone to talk to, I’m always here for you.”

Adora didn’t have the heart to tell Mrs. Netossa the real reason she felt so off, considering she’d been the one who encouraged her to talk to Dr. Prime. She gave her teacher an unconvincing smile, thanking her for her kind words, before grabbing her bag and rushing to the bathroom to cry.

Oh god… I’m in love with Catra.

It felt like a cruel twist of fate, not only had she driven Catra away, she was now realising that her feelings for the brunette were more than just friendship, emerging to swiftly slice her heart in two so that she wouldn’t survive the pain and torture that was taking over her life.

She didn’t leave the bathroom for hours on end, swinging between earth shattering sobs and quiet sniffles, by the time she did leave, school hours were coming to a close, and Adora didn’t want to be locked inside the building.

When she got home, she needed something, *anything*, to pull her away from the heartbreak clawing at her chest, threatening to slice her heart into two. That was when she noticed the razor in her bathroom cabinet.

That was the first night she sliced her wrist, but it wasn’t the last.

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“We’re trying something new today.”

That made Adora look up at Dr. Prime, trying to gauge his feelings, but the older man maintained his poker face.

“What does that mean?” She asked, not bothering to hide how wary she felt about this. This research project was growing worse by the day, just yesterday they didn’t even bother giving her a hospital gown. She was naked in front of *everyone*, it took everything in her not to break down.

Prime turned to face her and gave her a smile that sent a shiver down her spine. That look was enough for her to know that whatever it was, she would not enjoy it. She turned to face ahead, hugging herself tightly as she tried to think about things that made her happy, like bunny rabbits, kittens, Catra curled up in her arms as they watched some horror movi- No. No. Adora could feel the tears in her eyes, no, stop it.

Dr. Prime took her to the main lab areas, only today all the tables and chairs were cleaned out, leaving the entire room empty except for a bunch of interns gathered together, and they fell silent as soon as they saw Adora.

This was new, interns were never allowed Adora. Dr. Prime insisted that only trained doctors and scientists that he approved of would examine her. Right now, she couldn't think of any good reasons he'd call them.

"What's going on?" She asked Dr. Prime, turning to him as she clenched her fists at her side.

"We're going to test your voice today, Adora." He said calmly, his smile turning almost manic.

"My *voice?"* What did he mean by testing her voice? She was speaking just fine.

"Have you not heard of the legend that a siren's voice is their sharpest weapon? It is what they use to lure sailors to their death." Dr. Prime replied enthusiastically, and the slow realisation made Adora go cold.

He wanted to see if she could essentially mind control people, and these interns were his fucking guinea pigs.

"It won't work, my voice doesn't work like that." Adora immediately said, her ears flicking back and forth nervously. In all honestly Adora didn't know if her voice was magical, she'd been too scared to see. Catra had offered herself up so that the blonde

could try, but she turned it down. In all honesty, she was terrified of the answer, terrified of feeling less human than she already did.

"It doesn't?" Prime asked, hands behind his back as he watched Adora like she was his personal nature documentary, every single reaction just broadcasted for his entertainment.

"It really doesn't." She insisted, hoping he'd take the bait and just drop the topic. As expected, he did not.

"Then however did you find Ms. Lily-Rose? She's *devoted* to you."

Adora opened her mouth, and then closed it, baffled at the insane question Dr. Prime had the guts to ask. There's no way he's implying what she *thinks* he's implying, right?

"I beg your finest pardon?"

"Ms. Lily-Rose is devoted to you, surely you used your voice for that? I'm sure it is entertaining to have someone waiting beside you like that, like a pet." He responded with a shrug, and Adora felt her blood **boiling**.

"I did not fucking *mind control* my best friend! Like I said, my voice can't even **do** that." She hissed, her eyes flaring so that this man would *get the fucking point*. Honestly, where did he even get the audacity to ask that?

"You did not?" He was humoring her because he *didn't fucking believe her*. She didn't. She didn't mind control Catra, right?

Their friendship was because she **wanted** it. Catra had wanted it, all of it. Her affection, her love, she'd wanted all of it.

Catra wanted it… Right?

What if she hadn't… What if Adora had actually done something to her, but she'd never noticed? What if Catra had never wanted their friendship… What if that friendship breakup was because whatever spell Catra was under had faded?

What if their friendship never existed?

Prime smirked when he saw Adora deliberating the question. She glared at him.

"I **didn't** do anything to her." Adora insisted, but it sounded tenuous even to her own ears.

"You don't know that though, do you?" Dr. Prime added, pushing the very thoughts that Adora had avoided all her life, those insecurities that she'd buried and refused to acknowledge. The very things that made her choose the dance performance over the band during the Farewell party for her seniors in her eleventh grade.

She never knew, and those answers *terrified* her.

"You can find out now." He gestured to the interns he'd gathered, watching as Adora grabbed her jeans nervously. "You can know what you're truly capable of, measure your potential."

Dr. Prime placed a hand on her shoulder, pushing her forward towards the interns. "All you have to do is *sing*."

She was just trying to see how powerful she could be, Adora wasn't hurting anyone. Maybe if she tried, she'd be able to tell the difference between someone who was under her spell and someone who wasn't, or she'd find out she had no such power and she'd *never* have to worry.

All she had to do was sing. She probably didn't even have anything to worry about, and now she'd know for sure.

Adora cleared her throat, feeling her heart crash into her chest. She started to hum a random tune from a song she'd heard playing on Mara's radio, and for a moment, nothing changed. It was slow, but she watched as the interns turned to face her, their pupils blowing out as she was met with their intense focus.

It shook her very core, and she covered her mouth with her hands and screamed into them. It broke the spell almost immediately, they shook their head and turned to one another, clearly surprised that it worked.

There was no one else in the room. It was her. Adora did that. She wasn't some diluted human girl with siren features, she had their powers.

"Brilliant!" Dr. Prime exclaimed, coming to face Adora while completely ignoring her horrified expression. "You did brilliant. If you harness this power, imagine what you could do!"

Adora wasn't listening, all she could think of was Catra, her beautiful bi-colored eyes, and her blown out pupils everytime she saw the blonde. Everything she'd ever known about their friendship was coming crashing down.

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Adora was losing track of herself. Over the last few weeks, Dr. Prime did nothing other than test the limits of her powers. He made her treat his interns like puppets on a string, toying with them they were her barbie dolls. She could feel it tearing pieces of her soul, and she felt herself growing distant from everyone around her. Adora curled into herself for support, because she knew no one would understand the torment she was facing.

The worst day was when Dr. Prime ordered her to ask his intern to choke his girlfriend in front of everyone. Adora wanted to refuse, that was her line, she wouldn't force them to hurt others, but she was scared. She was a fucking *coward*. She didn't know what Dr. Prime would do to her if she refused.

Adora watched as the young man wrapped his arms around his girlfriend's neck, watched as his girlfriend begged for mercy while Dr. Prime watched with sadistic joy. She couldn't sleep through the night, knowing what she'd done to that terrified girl.

She had an event the next day, some guest lecture that she had to arrange through tears and exhaustion. Adora couldn't take it, the guilt, the pressure, the pain. The stress of studies, the student council, and Dr. Prime weighed on her chest and her mind. She needed a moment to herself, one single moment to breathe.

Adora ran into an empty classroom near the auditorium, shutting the door behind her and crumbling on top of a chair, resting her head on the table as she sobbed.

What am I doing with my life? Why am I letting him control me like this? Why do I keep doing whatever he says? She thought to herself, digging her hands into her hair, tugging on the strands to feel the pain, distract it from the heartache that threteaned to rip her soul out of her body.

She wanted to stop, she wanted to run, she wanted to hurt Prime the way he made her hurt that poor girl. Adora couldn't get her sobs out of her head when she released her boyfriend from her control. She watched as the girl shoved him away, running out of the lab into the hallway, gripping her neck and gasping for air. Adora wanted to slam Prime into the wall, make him suffer for thinking he could just use his interns as guinea pigs.

Adora was angry, but she was also broken by life and by her own emotions. She felt so much but she couldn't *do* anything about it. At least, nothing more than cry in an empty, dark classroom when no one was looking.

She was broken, unlovable. She was facing the concequences of her own actions.

The door opened slowly, Adora jumped up and glanced at the doorway, only to find her head spinning again. Catra was standing there, her ears drooping against her hair, camera in her hand as she watched the blonde nervously wipe away her tears.

"Mrs. Netossa is looking for you…" She whispered. "The guest is here, and she wants to start the event."

“Ah! Right.” Adora quickly pulled a tissue out of her pocket, she had to start carrying it everywhere so that no one noticed her mental breakdowns. She wiped off the tears completely, before tossing it in a dustbin and grabbing the papers containing her introductory speech that she’d written at two in the morning, in between breakdowns and ice cream.

“Are you okay?” Catra asked, watching Adora set herself right so that no one would know how badly she was suffering.

“Yup!” She looked over her shoulder and gave the brunette the most convincing smile she could manage. If there was anything this experience had taught her, it was how to smile pretty and get what she wanted.

“I know we aren’t really friends anymore, but you can still talk to me.” The brunette went on, but Adora shut it down almost immediately.

“I’m fine.” She replied forcefully, nodding while adjusting her casual button up. “Come on, let’s not keep our guest waiting.”

Standing at the podium while smiling at her classmates was a far cry from how she truly felt. It was a jarring change, and at least this experience was teaching her to mask her emotions well. One day, she told herself, it would useful for something good, and not to hide the scars on her wrists, and her heart.

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They were nearing Christmas holidays, and also the end of the research project. Adora couldn’t have asked for a better Christmas present. She walked through the halls of the facility with a sense of joy that she never had before. Of course that joy vanished right away when the guards informed her that she was to meet Dr. Prime in his office.

It didn’t matter. This whole arrangement was coming to an end. Adora would take the information and finally leave this cursed

project behind.

Dr. Prime was on the phone when Adora walked in, he gestured to a chair placed next to his own, and shaking quietly, she sat down next to him, her leg bouncing up and down. She kept her gaze trained to, terrified to look anywhere else, but she could feel his gaze on her, raking over body despite the fact that she was wearing a long-sleeved sweater paired with a skirt that reached her ankles. She dressed like that because of how handsy Dr. Prime was, yet nothing seemed to protect her from his gaze.

"Ah! Adora, I was expecting you." He greeted jovially, sitting down on the chair beside Adora, placing one hand on her knee to stop her leg from bouncing. She froze, that contact making her feel so uneasy that she had no idea how she was supposed to react.

"This project has gone amazingly, it's been a fantastic source of entertainment." Dr. Prime began, seeming so oblivious to Adora's turmoil. "I have learnt so much about you, and I believe you have learnt a lot about yourself as well?"

Adora simply nods in response, too paralysed by fear and disgust to respond.

"I have always told my subordinates and interns that there is so much to learn in the world around us, knowledge is abundant, and so are mysteries. I'm sure there is much to learn about you, Ms. Vespera. Don't you think?"

Adora didn't trust that, she didn't trust it one bit. "What do you mean by that?"

"I would love to keep this little arrangement going, but I'm sure it could be more beneficial to the both of us." He brought Adora's chair closer to his, his knee was crowding the blonde's, and she could feel her heart crashing and screaming, begging Adora to get away from this man.

"I know your relationship with your guardian and Ms. Lily-Rose has not been… ideal. I'm offering you a home, Ms. Vespera, my

own home in fact! You'll be introduced to the Elite Society, and as my lover, no one would dare to disturb you. All I ask in return is… co-operation in my endeavours."

Everything seemed to click into place.

He was never going to let her go, not when he had his claws in her too deep.

"Who knows, you may even have Ms. Lily-Rose back."

She snapped up to glance at him. "What the *fuck* do you mean?"

"Well, now that you know what you can do with your voice, you could use it." Dr. Prime suggested.

It was enough for her to snap.

"Absolutely not." She got up from the chair and grabbed the documents from her research project. "I'm done. I'm done with all of this. I've got what I wanted, I just want out."

Prime crossed one leg over the other, watching her with dismissive yet amused look. "I've done so many things during this whole "project" that I will regret for the rest of my life. So yeah, I'm done. I don't want *anything* to do with you. I want out."

For a moment, he didn't say anything. He just watched her, which was worse because it felt like she was being scrutinized. Adora just wanted to leave, she wanted to return to her home, her room, her *bed*, but it didn't seem like he wanted to let her go anytime soon.

"That really is unfortunate. I was hoping that it wouldn't come to this, Ms. Vespera." Prime said sorrowfully, and honestly this was the worst response he could've given.

"W-What…?" She whispered, gripping the documents in her hand.

“I have a lot of power in this area, Ms. Vespera. You do understand that I could do anything I wanted, right? I am good friends with the Chief of Police, and I have connections in the justice system. More importantly, I know where you go to school, *and* I know where you and Ms. Lily Rose live.”

She was shaking, air was too hard to take in, her vision was blurring, and her head was spinning. This was the absolute worst case scenario, and she wanted to cry, to scream and tell him he won’t get away with it.

He already did, because both of them knew no one would believe her.

“You have until next week to accept.” Prime said, before calling for his security to escort her out of the building.

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Home wasn’t the escape it usually was. She still felt heavy from the thinly veiled threat Prime had issued in his office. The walls were closing in on her, and Adora wouldn’t be able to run from them for much longer.

As she stepped through the door, the first thing she noticed was that Mara was waiting at the dinner table for her. That was new, her guardian was never around when Adora came home, Mara never wanted to be near her anymore.

“Adora…” She whispered, getting up when the blonde shut the door behind her.

“Is something wrong?” Adora asked, dropping her bag onto the couch.

“N-No. Uhm… I want to talk to you. It’s important.” Mara replied, gesturing to the dining table. “Dinner is ready, you can eat while we talk.”

Adora didn't want to talk, not with Prime's threat looming over her head. She still nodded, eager to speak to Mara after weeks of silence. She sat down on the chair, pulling her plate closer to her, smiling at the sandwich. It was her favorite.

"I'm so sorry, I haven't been talking to you for a while." Mara whispered, smiling down at her.

"Well neither have I, that night was uhm… bad." Adora replied, smiling back at her guardian.

"How has everything been for you?" The older woman asked kindly.

Adora nodded quietly in response. "Fine. Everything's been fine."

"I wanted to talk about that night, actually… about how you were born."

That caught Adora's attention. She placed the sandwich back on her plate and straightened her back, her full attention on Mara.

"I lied to you, Adora. Mainly about your birth, because I thought the truth would be too much for you. I'm realising now that it was a big mistake." Mara went on, and Adora could feel her guardian's leg bounce up and down under the table.

"You were a stillborn. It was… an awful few days after you were born. Marlena was heartbroken, she'd been so excited to have you. Randor and I did everything we could, but it was like she'd shut everyone out after you died. She'd already been researching about sirens, but after your death she dove into her birth, trying to find a solution to… to bring you back to life."

Adora gripped her sweater tightly. "A-And…?"

"She found out that men are the only targets of sirens. When sirens capture a woman… they're transformed into another siren. She and Randor were never travelling to a carnival or convention like I told you, they were travelling to bring you back to life. I

found out later when going through her notes. Your mother… she gave herself up to those sirens… and that's how you were born, Adora."

Distantly, Adora could hear her plate crashing into the floor and shattering, her sandwich falling down alongside it. Everything Mara was telling her sounded like a fever dream, and for a second she hoped that she was in fact dreaming, until she felt a slight pain shoot up her arm. She glanced down at her leg to find a few cuts on it because of the shattered plate.

"A-Adora!? Honey are you okay?" Mara yelled, pulling Adora's hands away from her hair, gripping them tightly to her chest.

"I'm a siren… an actual siren." Adora mumbled.

"Its okay, it doesn't matter. You're still my little girl." Mara replied, walking around the table and pulling Adora into her arms. The hug was tight, but Adora didn't reciprocate it. Her mind was faraway as she processed the fact she was, in a way, her mother. It was her mother's grief and desperation that led to her birth that night at sea.

It led to yet another sleepless night.

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She hadn't left her room in three days. Mara kept trying to get her to leave, but Adora was stubborn, and soon she gave up. On the fourth night, she finally kicked into action.

She wasn't supposed to live anyway, so if she took herself out of the equation, the world would be balanced again.

It was around two in the morning when Adora opened up her notepad and started to scribble a note into it, dedicated to Catra and Mara. Once she was done, she ripped it out of the pad and left the room, leaving it on the dining table.

Mara was sleeping on the couch, a bottle of wine next to her on the floor. Adora felt relieved knowing that her guardian wouldn't wake up as she finished the job.

Adora stepped onto the beach outside her home, walking over to the ocean with a sense of determination she'd never had before. With a quiet gulp, she stepped into the water, watching as her legs disappeared into the water.

It wasn't until she'd entered the water that she started to feel a sense of terror clawing at her throat, the panic that often accompanied the arrival of death. As she stood there on the bridge between life and death, she didn't feel the peace everyone told her she would, she felt cold, hard, fear. Everything in her brain screamed *I DON'T WANT TO DIE*.

Adora began to shake, squeezing her eyes shut as she tried to control her breathing. She had to do it so that Catra and Mara wouldn't have to deal with Prime. If she was dead, he would no longer have a reason to threaten them, and she would be able to escape him, finally.

The water continued to envelop her legs, for minutes she just stood there, enjoying the feeling of it, telling herself that in a minute, she'd end it all. One minute turned to two, two turned to ten, and she found that she was too scared to do it.

This is a lost cause, I should just go inside. Adora thought to herself. She opened her eyes and glanced down at her feet, only to gasp.

Her human-looking legs were completely covered this iridiscent scales, as soon as the waves swished away from her legs, they turned back to normal skin. She'd never seen this happen before, mostly because she didn't enjoy going near the water.

I wonder…

Adora pulled off the silky nightdress she'd been wearing, tossing it aside alongside her bra and underwear. The water was cold, and

the blonde felt herself shivering as she slowly entered it. The change felt like magic. Adora watched her legs shifted into scales, before merging together into a massive tail. The rest of her body followed suit, the scales that dotted her body like freckles spread all over her body as gills opened up on her chest. She fell into ocean, a soft giggle escaping her as breated in and realised that she didn't struggle underwater.

Adora didn't need to die. Not when she could swim away and never be seen again. It was the same thing, now no one would touch her, and her loved ones would be free. She swam away from the shore, her future suddenly filled with so many opportunities far away from the greedy hands of Hector Prime.

She was now one with the sea, her human life starting and ending in the same place.

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It was one night that changed everything. One night when Mara had drunk too much to notice footsteps crossing her and the front door opening, letting her little girl walk out into the darkness, towards the very water that had brought her to Mara seventeen years ago.

She'd only noticed when Catra slammed the door open, phone in her hand as she shook Mara awake.

"Adora texted me, where is she!? Mara *where is she*!?" Catra yelled, tears streaming down her face as she ran into Adora's room.

"What- C-Catra what's going on?" She asked, pushing herself off the couch and following Catra into Adora's bedroom.

"She texted me at like two in the morning, and all she said is *I'm sorry*. She's going to do something stupid, Mara **where is she**?" Catra replied, frantically shoving her phone into Mara's hand before running outside to check the other rooms in the house.

It was just as Catra said, Adora had texted the brunette with two words that sent a shiver down her spine. She dropped Catra's phone aside and joined her in searching the house for Adora, but it was quickly becoming clear that she was nowhere to be found.

It wasn't until they regrouped in the kitchen that they saw the note. It was placed on the kitchen table, and in neat handwriting that Mara recognised as Adora's, were the words *For Mara and Catra* written on top. Catra grabbed the note immediately and opened it so that the two of them could read it.

By the time you read this, it'll probably be too late. I'm so sorry for going like this, but I had no choice, Prime was threteaning to hurt you two, and I couldn't lose the two most important people in my life because of my mistakes. You were right, you were ***always*** *right, I shouldn't have accepted the proposal in the first place, he only wanted me for what I could provide for his image, and I* ***knew*** *that. I knew he was a scumbag, but I was selfish. I wanted to know more about myself, and I should've thought about the concequences of that decision.*

I'm an abomination anyway, from the moment I was born that night in the sea I was an abomination. I was never meant to exist, my mother gave her life to create me. It's so odd, knowing that I am my mother's flesh in a new form, but I am also her daughter. Not a lot of people can say that. It doesn't matter, like I said, I was never meant to exist, so taking myself out of the equation will be easy.

I'm so sorry for all the pain I caused you both, you only wanted to help me, save me from myself, but I fought every step of the way, said horrific stuff I never meant. Deep down, I knew you were right, but I simply didn't want to accept that I was at fault, and so I kept arguing, kept self-destructing. Maybe now you'll be able to find some reprieve now that I'm gone, taken away by the very sea that brought me here in the first place.

With love, Adora.

“No no no…” Mara whispered. “This isn’t- this isn’t *real*. She’s playing a joke on us!” She turned towards Catra, tears streaming down her face. “She’s p-playing a joke on us, right Catra?”

The brunette didn’t say anything, tears were filling her eyes and staining the piece of paper in her hands. Catra didn’t respond, she leaned against the table to balance herself as she gasped for air.

“Adora this isn’t funny!” Mara yelled, her voice bouncing off the walls in a haunting echo. “You can come out now!”

It was as though the words were enough to set Catra off, she fell to her knees in a crumpled heap, clutching the paper to her chest, the last remnant they had of Adora’s life, gasping and screaming in pain. Mara was quick to follow, pulling Catra against her chest in a side hug, letting the little girl press her face into her shirt, staining it with her despair.

It took them some time to pull away and kick into action. Mara dialed the police’s phone number with shaky hands to report Adora missing, and possibly dead. Catra walked into the kitchen on autopilot to make some tea for both of them, and it took the police less than twenty minutes to show up at their house. They took Catra and Mara’s testaments, before taking Adora’s note and preparing to organise a search in the sea for her corpse. Catra didn’t go to school, opting to stay back with Mara for support, and to make sure she was there for any information the police would provide.

“I won’t be able to focus with all this hanging over my head anyway…” Catra admitted, gazing down at tea that had cooled down a long time ago.

It took a few days for the police to return, Catra didn’t leave the house except to get clothes and toiletries. She slept off in Mara’s room (both of them were too emotional to enter Adora’s) while Mara took the couch. They were a mess the entire time, both of them taking regular breaks to lock themselves in a room and sob into their clothes.

Guilt consumed them the entire time, a mixture of *what-ifs* that only sent the two of them spiralling. Mara kept wondering if things would've been different if she'd been forthcoming about Adora's true origins, it was her lies that pushed her young girl into the arms of Prime. If Adora had known the entire time, would she have been less inclined to go seeking out answers?

It was a dangerous rabbit hole, one that had her crumpling into a puddle on the couch, too terrified to drown out her sorrows with drinks, those were reason she'd missed Adora sneaking out of the house on that fateful night, and too guilty to keep living knowing she'd once again outlived another family member, one she'd promised to Marlena that she'd protect.

The search yielded no results, the police returned to the house, their heads hung low as she explained that no matter how much they searched, they simply couldn't find Adora's body. It was as though the universe was actively against Mara. Not only could she not bury her sister and brother-in-law, now she didn't even have the chance to bury her daugh- *no*. Mara had no right to call Adora that, not after failing the blonde so monumentally. She had no chance to bury her niece either.

In one night, Mara lost *everything* she'd ever had to the cursed sea once more. It was like everyone she'd ever loved was doomed to die in the waters of something that seemed so utterly harmless. She wondered what god she'd pissed off to deserve such a fate, but in the end it didn't matter. Adora's death left her with a broken magicat, she owed it to her niece to look after the little girl.

In the end, it was the least she could do.

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Chapter End Notes

so wasn't this a fun read? feel free to murder me in the comments. thank you to Thia Kerrigan for beta'ing for me

End Notes

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